Voices from Chernobyl

By Svetlana Alexievich

Lyudmilla -- wife of fireman, Vasily Ignatenko

LYUDMILLA: (Pg 5-6) We lived in the dormitory of the fire station where he worked. One night I heard a noise. I looked out the window. Everything was radiant. The whole sky. "Close the window and go back to sleep," he said. "There's a fire at the reactor. I'll be back soon."

They went off just as they were, in their shirt sleeves. No one told them. They had been called for a fire, that was it. Four o'clock. Five. Six. Seven o'clock. I was told he was in the hospital. The police had already encircled it, shouting "The ambulances are radioactive, stay away!"

[When] I saw him. He was all swollen and puffed up. You could barely see his eyes. Many of the doctors and nurses in that hospital would get sick themselves and die. But we didn't know that then. **(Pg 7)** The doctors kept telling us they'd been poisoned by gas. Not one said anything about radiation. No one talked bout the radiation.

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DOCTOR: (Pg 9) All right, listen: his central nervous system is completely compromised. And if you start crying, I'll kick you out. No hugging or kissing. Don't even get near him.

LYUDMILLA: (Pg 12) It was a hospital for people with serious radiation poisoning. For fourteen days . . **(Pg 11)** Will they live? Live. **(Pg 12)** In fourteen days, a person dies. *[She is silent]* **(Pg 11-12)** He started to change – every day I met a brand-new person. The burns started to come to the surface. At first there were little lesions, and then they grew. I came off in layers – as white film . . . the color of his face . . . his body . . . blue . . . red . . . gray-brown. The only thing that saved me was it happened so fast; there wasn't any time to think, there wasn't any time to cry.

(Pg 17) They photographed him. Naked. One thin sheet on top of him. I changed that sheet every day, and every evening it was covered in blood. I pick him up, and there are pieces of his skin on my hand. They photographed him. For science, they said.

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INTRODUCTION

April 26, 1986 -- fourteen days after the worst nuclear accident in history, Lyudmilla Ignatenka lost her husband. Reactor #4 at the Chernobyl Nuclear Power Plant in what is now northern Ukraine exploded and burned. Scientists estimate the zone around the former plant will not be habitable for up to 20,000 years.

According to the official, internationally recognized death toll, just 31 people died as an immediate result of Chernobyl, these were the first responders. But over 600,000 people suffered from radiation poisoning that continues to impact generation after generation. Imagine being a mother and knowing that your children or future children are at risk.

Voices from Cherynobyl collected from interviews by Svetlana Alexievich in 1996.

Nadezhda Petrovna Vygovskaya -- mother

NADEZHDA: **(Pg 155-157)** It happened late Friday night. My husband says, "There's some sort of fire at the nuclear plant. They're saying we are not to turn off the radio." I forgot to say that we lived in Pripyat, near the reactor. I can still see the bright-crimson glow. [But] this wasn't any ordinary fire, it was shining. It was pretty.

That evening everyone spilled out onto their balconies. We were on the ninth floor, so we had a great view.

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People brought their kids out, picked them up, said, "Look! Remember!" And the people who worked at the reactor. . . They stood in the black dust, talking, breathing, wondering at it.

People came from all around on their cars and their bikes to have a look. We didn't know that death could be so beautiful. My throat tickled, and tears came to my eyes.

In the morning I woke up and I remember feeling something isn't right, something has changed forever. At eight there were already military people on the streets in gas masks. When we saw them on the streets, we didn't grow frightened -- on the contrary, it calmed us down. Since the army has come to our aid, everything will be fine. We didn't understand then that the peaceful atom could kill, that man is helpless before the laws of physics.

All day on the radio they were telling people to prepare for an evacuation. We settled in Mogilev and our son started school, he came back the very first day in tears. They put him next to a girl who said she didn't want to

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sit with him, he was radioactive. Our son was in the fourth grade, and he was the only one from Chernobyl in the class. The other kids were afraid of him, they called him "Shiny." His childhood had ended so early.

Larisa Z -- mother

LARISA Z: **(Pg 85-88)** My little daughter-she's different. She's not like the others. When she was born, she wasn't a baby, she was a little sack, sewed up everywhere, not a single opening, just the eyes. The medical card says: "Girl, born with multiple complex pathologies: aplasia of the anus, aplasia of the vagina, aplasia of the left kidney." That's how it sounds in medical talk, but more simply: no pee-pee, no butt, one kidney.

On the second day I watched her get operated on, on the second day of her life. She opened her eyes and smiled, and I thought that she was about to start crying. But, God, she smiled! The ones like her don't live, they die right away. But she didn't die, because I loved her.

In four years she's had four operations. She's the only

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child in Belarus to have survived being born with such complex pathologies. I love her so much. *[Stops]* I won't be able to give birth again. I wouldn't dare. I came back from the maternity ward, my husband would start kissing me, [and] I would lie there and tremble: we can't, it's a sin, I'm scared. I heard the doctors talking: "That girl was born in a suit of armor. If we showed it on television not a single mother would give birth." That was about our daughter. How are we supposed to love each other after that?

I went to church and told the minister. He said I needed to pray for my sins. But no one in my family has ever killed anyone. What am I guilty of? First they wanted to evacuate our village, and then they crossed it off their lists -- the government didn't have enough money. And right around then I fell in love. I got married. I didn't know that we weren't allowed to love here. Many years ago, my grandmother read in the Bible that there will be a time when everything is thriving, everything blossoming and fruitful, and there will be many fish in the rivers and animals in the forest, but man won't be

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able to use any of it. And he won't be able to propagate himself in his likeness, to continue his line. I listened to the old prophecies like they were scary fairy tales. I didn't believe them.

My daughter . . . She's four years old and she can sing, dance, she knows poetry by heart. Her mental development is normal, she isn't any different from the other kids, only her games are different. She doesn't play "store," or "school" she plays "hospital." She gives her dolls shots, takes their temperature, puts them on [an] IV. If a doll dies, she covers it with a white sheet.

We've been living in the hospital with her for four years, we can't leave her there alone, and she doesn't even know that you're supposed to live at home. When we go home for a month or two, she asks me, "When are we going back to the hospital?" That's where her friends are, that's where they're growing up.

After the last operation her urinary functioning completely broke down, and they were unable to insert a catheter. They'll need more operations for that.

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They've advised us to seek medical help abroad. Where are we going to get tens of thousands of dollars if my husband makes 120 dollars a month?

One professor told us quietly: "With her pathologies, your child is of great interest to science. You should write to hospitals in other countries. They should be interested." So I write. *[Tries not to cry.]* I write that every half hour we have to squeeze out her urine manually through artificial openings. Where else in the world is there a child who has to have her urine squeezed out of her every half hour? And how much longer can it go on? No one knows the effect of small doses of radiation on a child. Take my girl, even if it's to experiment. I don't want her to die. I'm all right with her becoming a lab rabbit, just as long as she lives. *[Cries.]* I've written dozens of letters. Oh, God!

She doesn't understand yet, but someday she'll ask us: why isn't she like everyone else? Why can't she love a man? Why can't she have babies? I wanted to get papers so that she'd know, when she grew up, it wasn't our fault, my husband and I. It wasn't our love that was at

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fault. *[Tries again not to cry.]*

I fought for four years with the doctors. I knocked on the doors of important people. It took me four years to finally get a paper from the doctors that confirmed the connection between ionized radiation and her terrible condition. They refused me for four years, they kept telling me: "Your child is a victim of a congenital handicap." What congenital handicap? She's a victim of Chernobyl!

I studied my family tree. Nothing like this has ever happened in our family. Everyone lived until they were eighty or ninety. My grandfather lived until he was 94. The doctors said: "We have instructions. We are supposed to call incidences of this type general sicknesses. In twenty or thirty years, when we have a database about Chernobyl, we'll begin connecting these to ionized radiation. But for the moment science doesn't know enough about it." But I can't wait twenty or thirty years. I wanted to sue them. Sue the government. They called me crazy, laughed at me. *[Beat]* There were children like these in ancient Greece, too. One

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bureaucrat yelled at me: "You want Chernobyl privileges! Chernobyl victim funds!" How I didn't lose consciousness in his office, I'll never know.

[Breaks down. Cries.] This girl is growing up -- she's still a girl -- even our neighbors don't know. I'll put a dress on her, and a handkerchief, and they say, "Your Katya is so pretty." Meanwhile I give pregnant women the strangest looks. I have all these mixed feelings: surprise and horror, jealousy and joy, even this feeling of vengeance.

(Pg 126) We're often silent. We're afraid to talk about it. We don't know how. [On April 26, 1986] the world was split in two: there's us the Cherynobylites, and then there's you, the others. **(Pg 133)** They've written dozens of books. Fat volumes, with commentaries. But the event is still beyond any philosophical description. **(Pg 187)** It's not just the land that's contaminated, but our minds.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
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